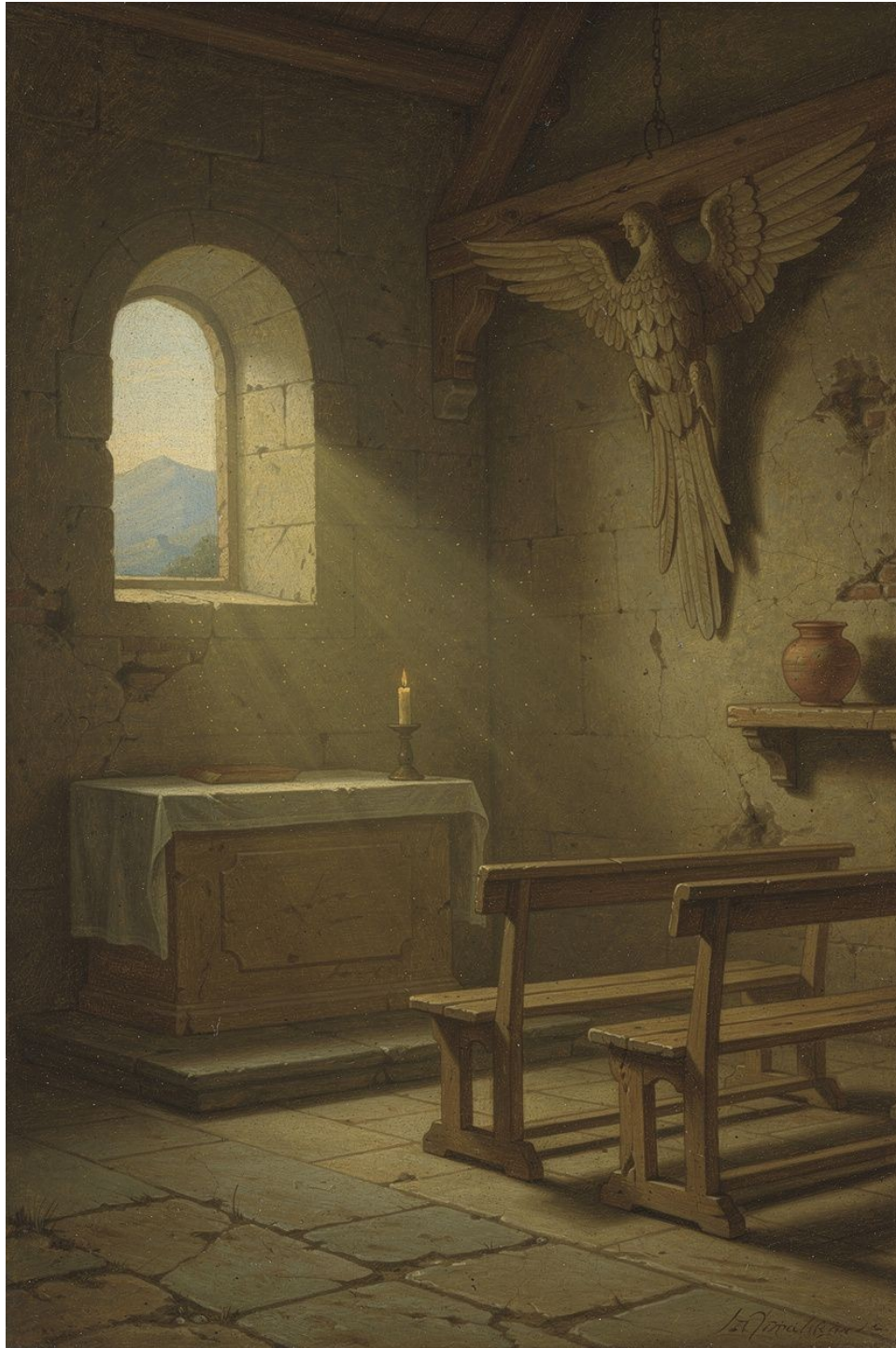




# Bonaventure: The Map of Six Wings

*WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10*



# Bonaventure: The Map of Six Wings

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

---

## About This Book

A long time ago, in a small hill town in Italy called Bagnoregio, a boy named Giovanni grew up. People later called him Bonaventure. That name means “good fortune.” Some stories say Francis of Assisi prayed for him when he was a sick child. We do not know if that story is exact. We do know this: Bonaventure loved Francis. He became a Franciscan friar. He became a teacher. He became the man who had to hold a huge, noisy family of brothers together.

This booklet tells six stories about him. Each one has a story, words he really wrote, a big idea, something to try, and a question to ask a grown-up. The questions are not tests. They are doors.

Bonaventure loved God. He loved Jesus. He loved books, and he loved prayer. He said you cannot have one without the other. He said the world is like a book God wrote. Keep that straight, and the stories stay true.

---



# Chapter 1: The Boy Named Good Fortune



*Illustration for Chapter 1*

Bagnoregio sits on a high ridge. The land drops away on both sides. A boy growing up there learned early that the world has edges. Giovanni di Fidenza was that boy. We are not sure if he was born in 1217 or 1221. Medieval writers did not always write birthdays the way we

do. What we know is that he grew up after Francis of Assisi had already lived and died. The brown-robed brothers were already walking the roads.

Later writers told a story: the child was very sick. His mother took him to Francis. Francis prayed. The boy got well. Francis said, “O bona ventura!” — “O good fortune!” — and the name stuck. Grown-up historians are careful with that story. It shows up late. Bonaventure himself did thank God for healing through Francis. That part we can hold.

When Giovanni was a young man, around 1243, he put on the Franciscan habit. He did not stay in a quiet village. He went to Paris. Paris was the biggest school in the Christian West. Students argued in Latin. Teachers sat in chairs that had names. Aristotle’s books were arriving in new translations. Some people were afraid of those books. Some people loved them too much. Bonaventure learned to use them without letting them become his god.

He studied under Alexander of Hales, a Franciscan master. When Alexander died, other teachers took over. In 1254 Bonaventure received the license to teach. He sat in the Franciscan chair of theology at Paris. Across the way sat another young master: Thomas Aquinas, a Dominican. They were not enemies. They were colleagues who disagreed about hard things. That is a kind of friendship too.

Paris in the 1240s was loud with a new problem. Aristotle’s books on nature and the soul were arriving through Arabic and Greek. Some teachers wanted to baptize every page. Some wanted to lock the gate. Bonaventure learned a third path: use the tools, name their limit. He wrote a huge *Commentary on the Sentences*, the textbook of the age, and a short *Breviloquium* — a “short book” for friars who could not live in a library. Seven parts, like seven days. Theology, for him, was not a pile of answers. It was a week that ends in rest.

He also wrote *The Tree of Life*, a gentler book. It is not a ladder of stages. It is a tree with twelve fruits from Jesus’s life: birth, teaching, the cross, the rising. Francis had made a Christmas crib at Greccio so people could see the baby. Bonaventure’s tree is a crib made of words. A child can enter a story. A master can still kneel.

So the boy from the ridge became a university teacher. He was not only a dreamer on a mountain. He was a man who had to think clearly in a noisy city, and who still wrote a tree for people who were not yet ready for Paris. Remember that. It will matter when the story goes to La Verna.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: Bonaventure’s life began with a town, a name that means good fortune, a brown habit, and a school — not with a statue. The name is a hope. The habit is a promise. The school is a tool. None of them is the journey yet. They are how the journey got a body. Even a Doctor of the Church started as a boy who had to be taught. The ridge came first. The chair came later. The map came last.

Keep the order when someone tries to start the story with a halo. Halo last. Start with the ridge. Then walk. Keep the story in that order.

### **Words to Remember**

*“In the beginning I call upon the First Beginning, from whom all illumination descends as from the Father of lights.”*

>

— Bonaventure, *\*The Soul’s Journey into God\**, Prologue 1 (Cousins)

Plain English: Before Bonaventure writes a map of the soul, he asks God for light. He does not start with “look how smart I am.”

### **Big Idea**

A wise life can begin in a small town and still need a school. Bonaventure’s “good fortune” was not luck. It was a life given back to God, then given to learning.

### **Try This**

1. Draw Bagnoregio as a town on a ridge. Put a small house, a road going down, and a road going out toward a big city. Label the city “Paris.” 2. Write your own name, then write what a kind grown-up might hope it means. Not a magic name. A hope. 3. With a grown-up, find Paris and Bagnoregio on a map of Italy and France. Trace the journey with a finger.

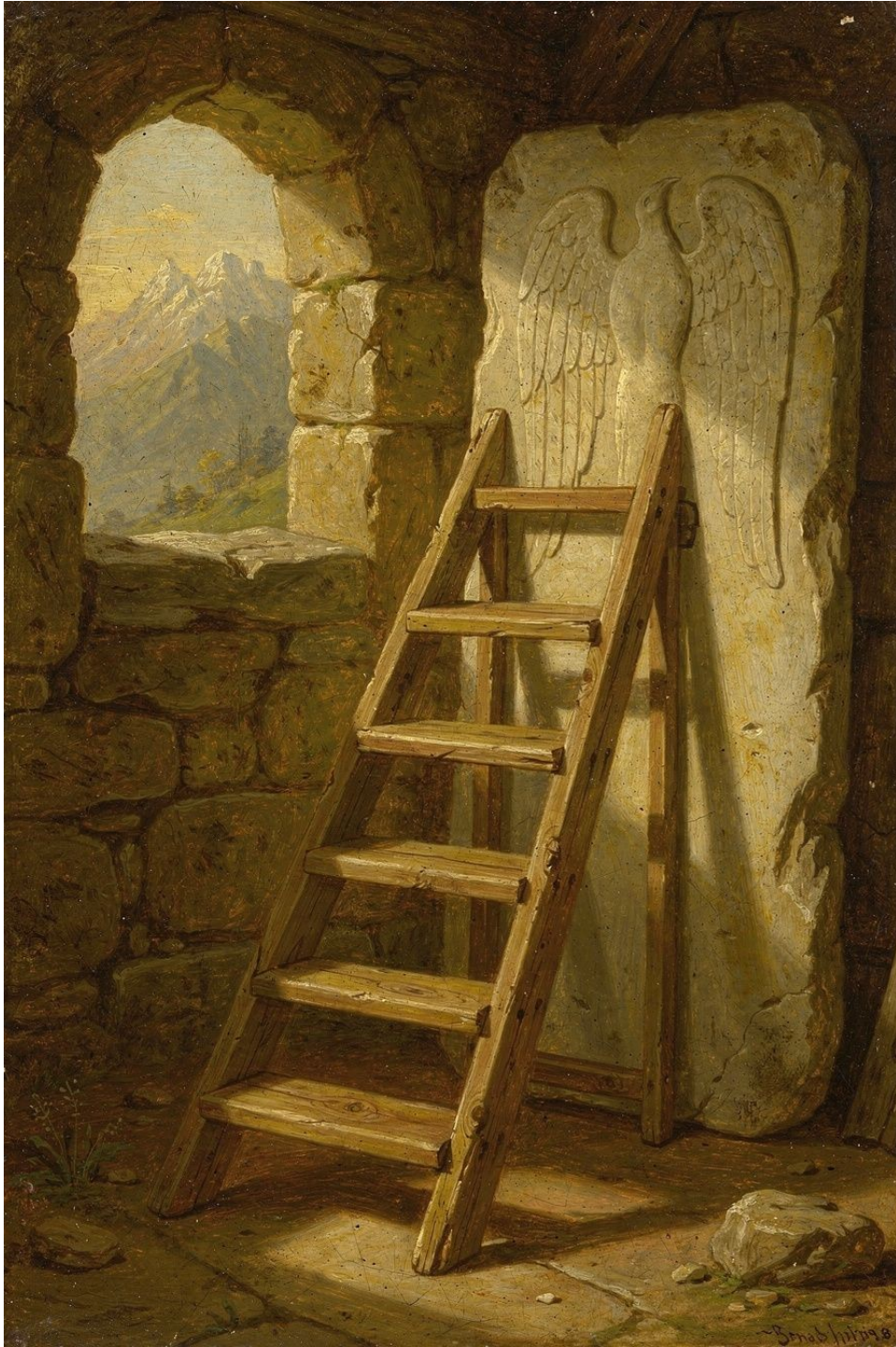
### **Ask a Grown-Up**

Who helped you when you were small, and how do we tell the difference between a true story and a pretty story?

---



## Chapter 2: Six Wings on a Mountain



*Illustration for Chapter 2*

In 1257 the Franciscan brothers chose Bonaventure to lead the whole Order. He was about forty. He had not asked for the job. The last leader could not hold the family together. Some brothers wanted to own nothing, not even as a group. Some brothers wanted buildings, books, and a calmer life. The Pope wanted peace. Bonaventure had to walk into that storm.

Two years later, in 1259, he went to a mountain called La Verna. Francis had gone there too. In 1224 Francis had seen a seraph — a fiery angel — in the shape of Jesus on the cross, with six wings. Francis's body later showed the wounds of the cross. People call those marks the stigmata. Bonaventure did not go to La Verna to copy a miracle. He went to think and to pray.

He says what happened in the first pages of his greatest book. He was seeking peace, like Francis. He was the seventh Minister General after Francis died. On that mountain, while he thought about how a mind climbs toward God, he remembered Francis's vision. Suddenly the six wings looked like six steps of light.

He wrote *Itinerarium Mentis in Deum*. In English people call it *The Soul's Journey into God*. An *itinerarium* is a travel plan. Bonaventure made a travel plan for the heart. Six wings. Six illuminations. Then a seventh step that is not a wing you count with your fingers: love that goes beyond knowing.

He is very clear about the door. You do not sneak in the side. You go through Jesus crucified. That is not a scary poster. It is Bonaventure's way of saying: God came close in a body that suffered. You do not climb to God as if you were a ladder all by yourself.

He numbered the climb. First you look at the world with your senses. Then you turn inside, where memory, mind, and will live. Then you see that those three powers are like a faint picture of God. Then you meet the hard truth: the picture is cracked. Sin broke it. You cannot polish it into God by yourself. Christ has to restore the image. After that you look toward God as one, then toward God as three persons, then into a bright darkness where love outruns the mind. Six wings, then rest.

The book is short. It is not a joke. He tells you not to race. Friars were meant to pray it, not skim it. Every stage is a kind of knowing and a kind of loving. Bonaventure the Paris teacher and Bonaventure the friar on the mountain become one writer on those pages.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: the map of six wings was written on a real mountain, after a real vision Francis had, by a man who had to lead tired brothers.

### **Words to Remember**

*"The figure of the six wings of the Seraph stands for the six stages of illumination, which begin with creatures and lead up to God, to whom no one has proper access except through the Crucified."*



— Bonaventure, *\*The Soul's Journey into God\**, Prologue 3

Plain English: The angel's six wings are six steps. The steps start with birds and stones and people. They end with God. The door is Jesus on the cross.

### ***Big Idea***

Bonaventure did not invent a maze to show off. He took Francis's vision and made it a path a praying person can walk: from the world, through the soul, through Christ, into God.

### ***Try This***

1. Draw a seraph with six wings: two down, two out, two up. Number them 1 to 6. Do not draw a face if it feels too hard. Wings are enough. 2. Walk six slow steps across a room. At each step name one created thing you are thankful for (water, bread, a tree, a friend, a song, sleep). 3. Fold a paper into a tiny "travel plan." On the cover write "Journey into God." Inside write: Start with the world. Go through Jesus. End in love.

### ***Ask a Grown-Up***

When have you needed a map for something you could not see — a hard year, a new school, a prayer you did not know how to say?

---

## Chapter 3: Footprints in the World



*Illustration for Chapter 3*

Bonaventure loved the world the way a reader loves a book. He did not think trees were God. He thought trees were footprints. He used a Latin word: *vestigia*. Vestiges. Tracks. If you see tracks in snow, you know someone passed by. You do not hug the tracks and call them the person. You follow them.

He said created things are copies of ideas in God's mind. That teaching is called exemplarism. A hard word. A simple picture: a potter has a bowl in mind before clay is on the wheel. God is not a potter who guesses. God knows what he makes. Every good thing is a small copy of a greater goodness.

He ranked the signs. Lowest: vestiges — the material world. Middle: images — the human soul, which remembers, thinks, and loves, like a faint picture of the Trinity. Highest: likeness — Christ, the perfect image, and a soul made like him by grace. You do not jump the ranks. You start with what your eyes can see.

That is why a Franciscan can love birds without worshiping birds. Francis called them brothers and sisters because God made them. Bonaventure explains the grammar. The world is sacramental: it is a sign that shares in what it points to, without becoming the One it points to.

If someone treats the earth like trash, Bonaventure would say they have stopped reading. They have turned a sentence into scrap paper. The first step of his journey is not "leave the world." It is "look."

Look, then climb. The ladder is Jacob's ladder in Scripture: up and down. You put the world of the senses in front of you like a mirror. Then you pass over toward God, the artist.

He would also tell you not to get stuck hugging the mirror. A child who loves a river can thank God for water. A child who calls the river God has stopped climbing. Bonaventure's ranks protect both love and truth. The world is good because it is made. The world is not the Maker. Francis sang to Brother Sun. Bonaventure explains why the song is allowed, and why the sun is still a creature.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: a leaf can teach you, but a leaf is not the Teacher.

### **Words to Remember**

*"Let us place the first step of the ascent at the bottom, putting the whole sensible world before us as a mirror through which we may pass over to God, the highest creative Artist."*

>

— Bonaventure, *\*The Soul's Journey into God\** 1.2 (Cousins)

Plain English: Start at the bottom of the ladder. Look at the world. Do not stop at the world. Let it be a mirror that sends you toward God.

## *Big Idea*

The world is God's book. Footprints are not the person. Love creation because it points; do not confuse the pointing finger with the One who points.

## *Try This*

1. Take a walk with a grown-up. Collect (or draw) three "footprints": a leaf, a stone, a cloud shape. For each, say one true thing it shows about goodness (strong, bright, giving shade). 2. Make a three-shelf drawing: Vestige / Image / Likeness. Put a tree on the bottom, a heart in the middle, a simple cross at the top. No magic symbols. Just the ranks. 3. Write one sentence: "This is not God, but it reminds me of God because..." Finish it with something you can see.

## *Ask a Grown-Up*

What created thing helps you remember God without turning that thing into a god?

---



## Chapter 4: The Light That Lets You Know



*Illustration for Chapter 4*

How do you know that two and two are four? How do you know that hurting someone on purpose is wrong? Bonaventure said your mind is real, and your eyes are real, but they are not enough by themselves for sure, unshakable truth. God lights the mind. He called that illumination.

He learned this from Augustine, a teacher who lived centuries earlier. Augustine said the mind sees unchanging truths in God's light, the way the eye sees colors in the sun. Bonaventure kept that. He also used Aristotle, who said we learn from the senses. Bonaventure did not throw the senses away. He said: senses start the work; God's light makes the knowing sure.

Thomas Aquinas, his Dominican colleague, said the mind God made can know truly by abstracting ideas from what we sense. God made good tools. The tools work. Bonaventure answered: the tools are finite and fallen. They can know this apple, that horse. They cannot, by themselves, explain why some truths must be true always.

This is not a contest to see who is nicer. It is a hard adult argument that even children can taste. When you understand a true thing, Bonaventure wants you to say thank you, not "I did that alone."

He named more than one lamp. There is light in making things, light in seeing, light in thinking, and a higher light in holy Scripture. A weaver, a farmer, a doctor, and a sailor all work in light. None of them is a fake theologian. None of them is the last word. All the lights come down from one Father.

He also said knowledge without love is a trap. You can read and still be cold. You can study and still be proud. The *Itinerarium* begins with prayer and ends with prayer. Before he lets you climb his ladder, he invites you to groan, to ask, to want God more than a grade.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: Bonaventure thinks every true thought is a kind of borrowed light.

### **Words to Remember**

*"Do not believe that reading is sufficient without unction, speculation without devotion, investigation without wonder, observation without joy, work without piety, knowledge without love, understanding without humility, study without divine grace, the mirror without divinely inspired wisdom."*

>

— Bonaventure, *\*The Soul's Journey into God\**, Prologue 4

Plain English: A book is not enough. You also need prayer, wonder, love, and humility. Otherwise the bright page can make you stumble.

### **Big Idea**

Knowing is a gift as well as a job. Bonaventure will not let the mind pretend it is a closed lamp. The lamp needs oil.

### *Try This*

1. Sit in a dim room, then open a curtain or switch on a lamp (with a grown-up). Notice: you did not invent the light. You received it. Say, "Thank you." 2. Copy one true sentence you did not make up ( $2+2=4$ , or "God is good"). Draw a small sun in the corner of the page. 3. When you finish homework tonight, add one line: "Knowledge without love is not finished." Then do one kind thing.

### *Ask a Grown-Up*

When have you known something was true, and who do you thank for being able to know?

---



## Chapter 5: The Man Who Held a Divided House



*Illustration for Chapter 5*

Leading the Franciscans was not a quiet desk job. The brothers stretched across Europe. Some were called Spirituals. They wanted Francis's poverty with no softening. Some were more relaxed. They thought a growing order needed houses, books, and rules that could work in cities. Both sides loved Francis. They did not love the same picture of him.



Bonaventure walked. The stories say he visited friaries from Assisi to Padua to Madrid to Paris. He wanted education for preachers. Some rigorists thought school smelled like pride. He thought an untaught preacher could harm people.

In 1263, at a chapter in Pisa, he presented the *Legenda Maior* — the *Major Life of St. Francis*. It became the official life. Later, other lives were pushed aside. Some people say he ordered older books destroyed. Scholars argue about that. What is sure is this: for a long time, the Francis most people knew was Bonaventure's Francis.

His Francis is the man who looks like Christ. Poverty is the condition for the mission, not the only point of the mission. Clare of Assisi fought for a poorer “nothing” as an end in itself. Bonaventure read poverty as a means: empty hands so you can preach, serve, and pray. That is a real difference. This booklet will not pretend they said the same sentence.

He also used a legal path the popes allowed: friars own nothing personally; goods can be used while someone else holds the title. Spirituals heard compromise. Moderates heard survival. Bonaventure heard a way to keep one family.

He had other storms too. At Paris, some teachers wanted the friars out of the university. Some brothers followed wild ideas about a coming Age of the Spirit that would replace the Church. Bonaventure had to say no to that without saying no to hope. He was a mystic who still believed in ordinary sacraments, ordinary popes, ordinary days.

Unity after he died did not last. Extremes pulled again. Later the Spirituals were crushed. That does not make his seventeen years of work nothing. It means holding a house is hard, and that a map of peace is not the same as a finished peace.

If you remember only one thing from this chapter, remember this: Bonaventure loved Francis enough to interpret him — and interpretation is not the same as making a person up.

### ***Words to Remember***

*“Our intent, then, is to show that in Christ are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge, and that He Himself is the central point of all understanding.”*

>

— Bonaventure, *\*Collations on the Six Days\** 1.11

Plain English: Bonaventure's center is not a party inside the Order. His center is Christ. Even the fight about poverty has to stand in that light.

### ***Big Idea***

A family can love the same father and still fight about the house. Bonaventure tried to keep the house by pointing everyone back to Christ, not by pretending the fight was imaginary.

### ***Try This***

1. Draw one house with two doors. Label one door “own nothing.” Label the other “use what we need.” Draw Bonaventure in the middle holding a rope that ties the doors. He is not a cartoon superhero. He is a tired brother. 2. Tell a true story of a time two people in your family wanted different rules. How did a grown-up keep peace without calling one child fake? 3. Read (with a grown-up) one short Francis story from an early source and one from “the official life” idea. Notice what gets emphasized.

### ***Ask a Grown-Up***

When two good people disagree about the same hero, how do we listen to both without lying?

---

## Chapter 6: All Knowledge Led Home



*Illustration for Chapter 6*

Bonaventure's inaugural lecture at Paris was a short work with a long name: *On the Reduction of the Arts to Theology*. Reduction does not mean "make smaller and throw away." It means "lead back." All the arts — weaving, farming, medicine, logic, physics,

ethics, even plays — are lights. They come down from the Father of lights. They are meant to go home to Scripture and to God.

He named four lights: the mechanical arts (making), the senses, philosophy, and sacred Scripture. None of the lower lights is trash. None is allowed to pretend it is the sun.

That is why a cobbler and a theologian can both be on the journey. A shoe can teach care. A harvest can teach gift. A song can teach joy. Then theology teaches what the shoe and the harvest were for.

He lived that circle. Mary sits and listens. Martha serves. Jesus says Mary chose the better part. Bonaventure will not let Martha be despised. The soul climbs, then returns to teach and to wash dishes. A later story says papal messengers found him washing dishes when they brought the cardinal's hat. He asked them to hang it on a tree until he finished. Maybe the story is too neat. The meaning matches the man we do have: a cardinal who was still a friar.

In 1273 Pope Gregory X made him Cardinal-Bishop of Albano. He helped prepare the Second Council of Lyon in 1274. For a short time East and West spoke of reunion. It did not last in the East. He died at Lyon on 15 July 1274. He was named a saint in 1482 and a Doctor of the Church in 1588: the Seraphic Doctor.

The last step of his map is not a cleverer book. It is love that outruns the mind. Chapter 7 of the *Itinerarium* talks about a “superluminous darkness” — a darkness that is bright because God is too much for our small eyes. He tells you to ask for fire, not for a lecture that never kneels.

He died in the middle of work, not in a quiet cave. The Seraphic Doctor is a nickname about burning love, not about a cartoon angel. Six wings. Four lights. One center: Christ. Then dishes, if the story is true, and a grave at Lyon if the dates are true. Both can teach a child the same lesson: go up, come back, keep serving.

If you remember only one thing from this book, remember this: every true art is a light, and every light is meant to go home.

### **Words to Remember**

*“If you ask how these things come about, ask grace, not instruction; desire, not understanding; the groaning of prayer, not diligence in reading; ... not light, but the fire that totally inflames and carries us into God.”*

>

— Bonaventure, *\*The Soul's Journey into God\** 7.6 (Cousins)



Plain English: At the end of the climb, you do not win a prize for being the best student. You ask for love's fire.

### **Big Idea**

Bonaventure spent his life leading knowledge back to God and leading a divided order toward peace. The last word is not an argument. It is a prayer.

### **Try This**

1. Make a four-box chart: Making / Sensing / Thinking / Praying. Put one thing you do in each box (draw, listen, homework, amen). 2. Help with a real chore — dishes, folding, sweeping — and while you do it, thank God for hands. Hang nothing on a tree unless a grown-up laughs and says yes. 3. Write a six-line “seraph poem”: world, soul, Jesus, light, peace, fire. One word per line is allowed.

### **Ask a Grown-Up**

What skill in our house (cooking, repairing, teaching, singing) do we want to “lead back” to God instead of treating as only useful?

---

## **For the Grown-Up Reader**

The stories follow Bonaventure's own works as translated in Ewert Cousins, *Bonaventure: The Soul's Journey into God, The Tree of Life, The Life of St. Francis* (Paulist Press, 1978), and Zachary Hayes's work on *On the Reduction of the Arts to Theology* (Franciscan Institute). The *Collations on the Six Days* line is the standard English of collation 1.11. Birth year (1217 or 1221), the childhood healing, the dishwashing cardinal, and any order to destroy earlier Francis lives are marked as uncertain, following Christopher Cullen and the layered Francis sources (Celano, the Assisi Compilation, Bonaventure's *Legenda Maior*).

Little-band edges: this booklet does not give children a medical account of stigmata, a verdict on East–West reunion, or pastoral advice. It does not turn exemplarism into pantheism. Poverty is named as a family fight, not a game.

Did he really say these things? The *Itinerarium* prologue and chapter 7, the *De reductione*, and Hexaëmeron 1.11 are his. Later charming stories are labeled as later.

---

## **About WisdomForge**

WisdomForge produces four age-adapted booklets for each figure: elementary (ages 5–10), middle (ages 11–14), high (ages 15–18), and adult. Each booklet covers the same person, ideas, and stories, but at a different level of depth and complexity. The elementary booklet

tells stories. The middle booklet explains ideas. The high booklet argues and analyzes. The adult booklet engages with scholarly debates and primary sources. Read the one that fits — or read them all and watch the same figure grow.